Just 10 days before the London Gatwick-bound Air India flight AI 171 crashed within seconds of takeoff in Ahmedabad on June 12, the airline had been busy staging its most high-profile media blitz since privatisation. On the sidelines of the International Air Transport Association's (IATA) annual general meeting in New Delhi from June 1-3, Air India's MD and CEO Campbell Wilson, flanked by the company's senior brass, met over 30 top aviation writers and editors from India and abroad. An upbeat Wilson spoke of how, three years after the Tata Group took over the beleaguered public sector airline, it had moved from a phase of stabilisation to one of sufficiency—finally having enough aircraft to fuel its ambitions. The next goal: sharpening operational efficiency. The makeover programme titled 'Vihaan.AI', which was unveiled in September 2022 and was slated to transform Air India as "a global airline with an Indian heart" in five years, was said to have reached a very satisfying halfway mark.

That image came undone with the crash of Air India's Boeing 787-8 Dreamliner—one of the deadliest in India's aviation history, killing 241 of the 242 people on board and at least 19 on the ground. The disaster thrust the Tata-owned airline into the harsh glare of media and regulatory scrutiny. In its immediate aftermath, the airline cancelled 83 international flights within a week and then announced a 15 per cent reduction in its widebody international operations through mid-July. Even as a high-powered, multi-agency committee, chaired by the Union home secretary, was given three months to probe the crash and suggest reforms, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) on June 20 pulled up Air India for repeated violations of crew duty norms and ordered the removal of three senior officials. The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau is learnt to have submitted its preliminary crash report to the Centre, though the findings remain undisclosed.

So, how did things come to this sorry pass? That too for a conglomerate that had an emotional stake in trying to reclaim its place in the sky? After all, Air India was born in 1932 as Tata Airlines, India's first aviation company. Founded by the iconic J.R.D. Tata, the group had lost control of the airline upon its nationalisation in June 1953. So when the Tatas formally re-acquired Air India nearly 70 years later—on January 27, 2022—it marked the end not only of a long phase

AIR INDIA vs INDIGO

AIR INDIA
(standalone data for the main carrier)

AGE OF FLEET

Less than 10 years	More than 10 years
65%	35%

CURRENT FLEET: 199

BOEING: 61
- 777 (W): 27
- 787 (W): 34

AIRBUS: 138
- A319 (N): 7
- A320 (N): 101
- A321 (N): 24
- A350 (W): 6

NEW ORDERS: 640*

BOEING: 220
- 737 MAX (N): 190 [2023-28]
- 787-9 (W): 20 [from late 2025]
- 777-9 (W): 10 [2025-27]

AIRBUS: 250
- A320neo (N): 140 [2024-29]
- A321neo (N): 70 [2025-30]
- A350 (W): 40 [2023-29]

**Other than those listed, includes option to buy 70 more aircraft from Boeing, plus a top-up of 90 A320/A321neos and 10 A350s from Airbus [2029-34]*

Note: As the delivery of new orders is ongoing, a few planes have already been inducted and will reflect in the current fleet figures too

AIR INDIA'S REVIVAL WAS ALWAYS AN UPHILL TASK—PLAGUED BY **AGEING AIRCRAFT, CULTURAL INERTIA AND YEARS OF NEGLECT** NO QUICK FIX COULD UNDO